Before we'd finished the picture I bought Baby, and not long after that I was able to buy my own ranch—eight acres in the San Fernando Valley—that fulfilled the dream I'd first had back in Des Moines. With Nino's help, I went into business, breeding thoroughbreds and selling them at the yearling sale.

During these early postwar years I found myself becoming increasingly involved with contract negotiations and other activities for the Screen Actors Guild.

As I look back now, I guess I was also beginning a political transformation that was born in an off-screen cauldron of deceit and subversion and a personal journey of discovery that would leave me with a growing distaste for big government.

I didn't realize it, but I'd started on a path that was going to lead me a long way from Hollywood. But that was a long way off and I sure never suspected it at the time.

I was back in pictures and loving it. After Warners brought several successful Broadway plays to the screen and cast me in starring roles, I didn't have much to complain about. But I did wish Jack Warner would think of me on the back of a horse wearing a cowboy hat.

He always wanted to cast me in drawing-room comedies in the kind of parts that might have gone to Cary Grant. I was hungry to do action pictures. I believed the war had given audiences a taste for action—not necessarily more war movies, because they'd had four years of those, but adventure and outdoor pictures, especially westerns. But when I'd ask Jack to put me in a western, he'd cast me in another movie in which I'd wear a gray-flannel suit.

In his defense, it wasn't only Jack Warner who acted like that. That was the way Hollywood operated: If I'd played a sailor in a picture that made a lot of money, I'm sure I would have had to buy a ton of seasick pills because I wouldn't be seeing land for years.